Steps, NEAT and cardio: how much and when

Hours on the treadmill are not the way. You burn most of your daily energy outside the gym, by walking and everyday movement. I'll show you why steps are more effective and easier to keep up than grinding out cardio, what role cardio plays in fat loss, and how not to eat it back as a "reward". Practical and based on science.

NEAT: the quiet lever of energy expenditure

NEAT (non-exercise activity thermogenesis) is the energy you burn through all the movement that is **not** planned training: walking, standing, stairs, pacing, gestures, restlessness. And it adds up to a lot: NEAT differs between people by hundreds of calories a day, and it is the most variable part of daily energy expenditure [1]. Two hours in the gym are only a small piece of the day. What you do with the other twenty-two hours decides.

The catch: NEAT is "smart" and can pull itself down. When you add hard cardio or cut calories, your body often **quietly takes it back** somewhere else: you move less outside of training, you sit more. That is why two people on the same training lose weight differently [7]. Tracking your steps on purpose prevents this drop.

> **Main idea:** Your expenditure depends on much more than that one hour in the gym: it depends on the whole rest of the day. **NEAT and steps** are a lever that many people leave unused [1].

Why steps, not hours on the treadmill

Steps are great because you can **dose them, measure them and keep them up**. You don't need to get mentally ready for them or recover from them, you just collect them during the day. As a rough guide, aim for **~7–10 thousand steps a day** (the exact number is not sacred, it is about the trend).

- ✓ A higher daily step count is linked with **lower overall mortality**: the benefit rises with the count and levels off at around 7-9 thousand steps/day [5].
- ✓ For health, what counts most is the **total number of steps**, not how fast you walk. Ordinary walking counts too [6].
- ✓ Walking **hardly drains you**: it doesn't hit your recovery or your appetite the way hard cardio does, so you can keep it up long term.

- ✓ An **hour on the treadmill** is easily "cancelled out" by one extra snack. Steps spread over the day are a quieter but more reliable expenditure.

Cardio in fat loss: an add-on, not the main tool

This is where most mistakes happen. Cardio will **not do the fat loss for you**. It helps to **create and keep a calorie deficit**, but on its own it is a weak tool for fat loss. Exercise without changing your food usually leads to only a small loss, because the energy cost of exercise is smaller than people think, and the body is happy to make up for it with a higher intake [2,3].

- ✓ For weight loss, your **diet** (the deficit) comes first, and cardio is an **add-on** that makes the deficit bigger or helps keep it [2,3].
- ✓ A big share of people **lose less than they expected** from exercise alone, because of compensation (more food, less NEAT) [7].
- ✓ Where cardio shines: **keeping the weight off** after you lose it. Regular exercise is one of the strongest predictors that the kilos don't come back [8].

> **Don't eat back your "reward":** "I ran it, so I deserve..." is a trap. Exercise often raises appetite and tempts you to make up for it and even overshoot [7]. Cardio does not earn you extra food. Handle food separately, by your goal, and not by what you "worked off".

Cardio vs. strength training for body composition

When it comes to how you look (how much muscle and how much fat you carry), strength training is king. In a direct comparison, aerobic exercise alone burns a bit more calories during the session, but it **doesn't build muscle**. A combination of aerobic and strength training, or resistance training alone, leads to **better body composition** (more muscle, a better ratio) than cardio alone [4].

- ✓ **Strength training** builds and protects muscle. That supports your metabolism, your strength and your shape [4].
- ✓ **Cardio** adds expenditure and fitness, but on its own it isn't enough for muscle.
- ✓ If you want to get lean and defined, the order of priorities is: **food (deficit) → protein + strength training → steps/NEAT → cardio as an add-on**.

HIIT vs. LISS: which one when

No type of cardio is "better" across the board, each one fits a different situation. **LISS** (low intensity, long duration: brisk walking, easy cycling) and **HIIT** (short intervals at full effort) each have their place. Choose based on how much time you have and how much recovery you have left after strength training.

1 LISS = the base

Brisk walking, easy cycling. Hardly affects recovery, easily adds expenditure and steps. Ideal for most days and for beginners.

2 HIIT = the add-on

Short intense intervals, done fast. Works when you are short on time, but it is demanding on recovery.

3 Watch your recovery

A lot of HIIT next to strength training takes a bite out of your recovery and your NEAT [7]. Don't do HIIT right before a leg session.

4 Pick what you can sustain

The best cardio is the one you will really do for weeks. If you hate intervals, do LISS and steps.

How to add steps to your day

You don't have to set aside an hour. Steps are best collected **in small bits**, woven into your normal day. A few habits and the number rises by itself:

1 Set a target

Measure your average for a few days and add ~1-2 thousand steps. Work gradually toward ~7-10 thousand/day [5,6].

2 Walk on the phone

A call = pacing. Take meetings and podcasts standing and moving.

3 Park farther, take the stairs

Small bits of friction in your favor: farther from the entrance, skip the elevator, walk one stop.

4 A walk after meals

10-15 min after lunch and dinner. It adds steps, helps digestion and settles your appetite for the next meal.

Action step: This week do just one thing: find out your **average step count** and add ~1,500 a day to it. Keep cardio as an add-on to your deficit, not the main tool [2,3], and don't make up for it with food [7]. **Strength training** keeps your muscle and shape [4]; **food and steps** control your weight. Small daily steps last longer than hours of grinding cardio. Be Effective! 💪

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Sources: [1] Levine JA. Non-exercise activity thermogenesis (NEAT). Best Pract Res Clin Endocrinol Metab. 2002;16(4):679–702. [2] Donnelly JE, et al. ACSM position stand: appropriate physical activity intervention strategies for weight loss and prevention of weight regain. Med Sci Sports Exerc. 2009;41(2):459–471. [3] Swift DL, et al. The role of exercise and physical activity in weight loss and maintenance. Prog Cardiovasc Dis. 2014;56(4):441–447. [4] Willis LH, et al. Effects of aerobic and/or resistance training on body mass and fat mass. J Appl Physiol. 2012;113(12):1831–1837. [5] Paluch AE, et al. Daily steps and all-cause mortality: a meta-analysis of 15 international cohorts. Lancet Public Health. 2022;7(3):e219–e228. [6] Lee IM, et al. Association of step volume and intensity with all-cause mortality in older women. JAMA Intern Med. 2019;179(8):1105–1112. [7] King NA, et al. Individual variability following 12 weeks of supervised exercise: compensatory responses. Int J Obes.

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